

Europe's growing pains

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GABRIEL GAVIN GOOD MOR

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GOOD MORNING. I'm Gabriel Gavin, wishing a happy International Youth Day to those of you who are young enough to celebrate ... and safe eclipse-watching to everyone looking up at the skies today!

In today's Playbook:

- The Commission is backtracking on one of its new packaging waste rules.
- Where to watch the eclipse in Brussels — just remember your eye protection.
- Faces in the crowd: Jessika Roswall, Marta Kos, Count Binface, Bjoern Seibert, Chickeletta the chicken and more.

DRIVING THE DAY

OPERATION UNBLOCK: European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen is gearing up for a fight with EU capitals over plans to admit new members — and has just weeks to convince them she can manage the risks of expanding the bloc.

The Berlaymont is drawing up a proposed redesign of the rules for new joiners, which will be put to EU leaders at a European Council kicking off on Oct. 15, three senior officials working on the issue, granted anonymity to discuss the sensitive plans, told Playbook. The overhaul is intended to assuage concerns that it will be even harder to make decisions and share resources if the group of 27 countries gets bigger.

The long road to membership: Montenegro is hoping to join by 2028, with Ukraine and Moldova planning to follow behind and Iceland weighing up whether to restart talks. While EU governments are publicly supportive of them joining, the likes of France, Germany and the Netherlands have voiced opposition to moving too quickly, worrying that new members could change governments and block key policies — as happened with Hungary under former PM Viktor Orbán.

"There's a reason the enlargement process takes decades," said a diplomat from a skeptical country. "The fear is we bring in a Trojan horse."

Reputation on the line: Despite von der Leyen repeatedly insisting enlargement is a geopolitical necessity, she risks presiding over the longest period in history without new members being admitted if she can't unblock the system before she leaves office in 2029. In March, her chief of staff Bjoern Seibert was told by ambassadors to go back to the drawing board because plans to supercharge the application process were unworkable.

Fresh from that drawing board ... Von der Leyen's Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos told Playbook that Brussels recognizes the need to "strengthen the political support of all 27 member states" and confirmed "the Commission will soon make proposals [on] how to prepare for a larger union." That will include firming up the rights and responsibilities of new members, as well as safeguards designed to strip them of their ability to derail decisions if they don't live up to their obligations. The final details are still under wraps.

Searching for direction: Montenegro has begun drafting its treaty, while Ukraine, Moldova, Albania and others are working through the required "clusters" of reforms. But they can only go as fast as EU capitals will allow. "We've done all we can at a technical level," said one diplomat from a country supportive of bringing in new members. "Now we need decisions at the political level."

The process is proving difficult. Orbán may no longer be in power, but Hungary has still not given the green light for the opening of all the negotiating clusters for Ukraine and Moldova, three officials working on the issue confirmed. "There is a bit of a push for Hungary to move forward," said one official, arguing the October meeting will be a chance to pressure Budapest to back down.

BIG AND BREAKING

STAYING ONLINE: Banning minors from social media is meant to be a vote-winning policy — but some young people, politicians and companies are fighting back .

TALIBAN TIES: Afghan nationals living in Germany are increasingly worried Berlin is teaming up with the theocratic regime back home to deport migrants, Nette Nöstlinger writes this morning.

GAZA DOUBTS: U.S. allies are worried that Israel's dismissal of Washington's Gaza plan will undermine Donald Trump's Board of Peace and his administration's influence over the Middle East more broadly, my stateside colleagues report.

UNDER WRAPS

PACKAGE NOT DELIVERED: The European Commission is urging capitals not to punish companies that struggle to comply with new EU packaging rules that take effect today, as it pushes to unwind one of the most burdensome requirements.

The rules are designed to cut packaging waste by forcing companies to use less material, make more of it recyclable and contribute to disposal costs. They also require businesses selling across borders to appoint an authorized representative in every EU country they ship to.

Change of tune: The Commission proposed that requirement in 2022, at the height of the Green Deal. With competitiveness and cutting red tape now higher up the agenda, it says the country-by-country requirement places an unnecessary burden on EU firms.

The Commission wants to scrap the representative requirement for EU-based companies, but the Parliament and Council have yet to agree the change. Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall told Playbook that having one EU packaging regime rather than 27 national ones “is good news for businesses,” but said the representative requirement is unnecessary.

Industry is angry: Businesses say compliance is already costly enough that some could stop selling into parts of the bloc. The European Paper Packaging Alliance told my colleague Ketrin Jochecová that the regulation “has taken up considerable resources” when companies are already dealing with “challenging economic times and increasing bureaucracy.”

We’re fine with no fine: That leaves the Commission in the awkward position of asking national authorities not to come down too hard on companies that breach a rule it now wants to change. “We have been very clear that there should not be any penalties, any sanctions indeed for anybody, for anything as of tomorrow basically,” said a senior Commission official, granted anonymity to speak frankly.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

VON DER LAYING (EGGS): The European Commission president is asking the public to help name two new chicks hatched by her hen Chickeletta during the summer break. Playbook suggests Jean-Clawed Clucker and Charles Mi-shell. Have your say here .

BALKAN BUST-UP: Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy’s visit to Serbia has exposed long-standing divisions over whether to recognize Kosovo, Una Hajdari writes from Pristina.

HOSTAGES OF WAR: The U.N. estimates that more than 16,000 civilians detained by Russia during its war in Ukraine are still being held against their will, per the Associated Press.

BIN ON THE BALLOT: Voters in the U.K.’s Clacton-on-Sea will get their chance this week to decide whether to re-elect Nigel Farage as their MP or hand the seat to his new arch-rival: a man with a bin on his head. Sam Blewett has the story .

BAD START TO THE DAY: From orange juice to coffee and pancakes, European breakfasts could get much more expensive if Brussels’ pesticide plans move ahead, Ketrin Jochecová reports.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny. High of 32C.

BLOCKING OUT THE SUN: Today’s partial eclipse will be visible in Belgium from just after 7:15 p.m. until nightfall. Around 90 percent of the sun will be blocked by the moon, but it will be most obvious if you can find a spot with clear views and minimal light around. Playbook last week offered up options for those wanting to book spaces at roof terraces and other venues across the city. But if you’ve left that too late, head for one of the city’s parks and find a hill.

Options, options: The north side of Park Duden, for example, is set to have one of the better views, while BRUZZ recommends getting away from the center to Zavelenberg nature reserve or Le Trèflerie in Woluwe-Saint-Pierre. Sunset Atlas has an interactive map of the best views in town .

Outside of Brussels? Lucky holidaymakers in Bilbao, Santiago de Compostela and northern Spain will have the best views — sitting right in the path of the total eclipse, which will pass around 8:30 p.m. Hotels in Iceland are booked up with those hoping to catch it earlier. Just remember: Don't look directly at the sun!

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Embattled SPD leader Lars Klingbeil will take a turn in the spotlight today , chairing Cabinet while Friedrich Merz is on holiday.

London: Andy Burnham will lead an emergency meeting today in response to Britain's heat waves.

Washington PM: A nail-biting Democratic Senate primary in Minnesota will be a real test of how much immigration matters to the party's base.

Playbook came to Brussels in 2015 and changed how this town starts its day. On 17 August it lands in Canberra: a capital with just as many officials and, until now, no daily briefing of its own. Canberra Playbook: free, daily, radically impartial. Subscribe free .

BIRTHDAYS

Former French President François Hollande; Enrico Gasbarra, former MEP; European Healthcare Distribution Association's Kasper Ernest; George Soros, Hungarian-American investor, philanthropist and POLITICO 28 alum.

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